

REUSABLE DIRECTIVE

Optimal Task Brief

A practical template for giving Codex the context, authority, constraints, and finish line needed to deliver excellent work.

THE RULE Fill the Essentials every time. Add only the optional modules that materially change the work. Delete guidance text before sending if you want a cleaner brief.

How to use this template

- Start with the outcome: describe the finished result, not just the activity.
- Supply the context and source material that would change a good decision.
- State boundaries, permissions, and irreversible actions explicitly.
- Define how the result will be checked and what “done” means.
- For quick tasks, send only the one-minute brief below; omit the rest.

One-minute brief

Outcome	[What should exist or be true when finished?]
Context	[Why this matters; audience; current state.]
Inputs	[Files, links, examples, data, or prior work to use.]
Constraints	[Must / must not; deadline; format; scope; risk.]
Done when	[Tests, review criteria, and expected handoff.]

1. Essentials

Complete this section for every task. Be concrete; short answers are enough.

Task name [Short, recognizable label]

[Type here]

Desired outcome [Describe the final state or artifact.] *Example: “A tested Python CLI that converts Suite2p outputs into tidy CSV files.”*

[Type here]

Why this matters [Decision, workflow, user need, or problem this supports.]

[Type here]

Audience / user [Who will read, run, approve, or maintain the result?]

[Type here]

Current state [What exists now? What has already been tried?]

[Type here]

Inputs and sources [List or attach files, folders, links, examples, datasets, and source-of-truth material.]

[Type here]

SOURCE PRIORITY If sources conflict, identify the authority order. Example: “The attached protocol overrides README text; existing tests override comments.”

Deliverable(s) [Exact artifact, answer, change, or action expected; include format and location.]

[Type here]

Out of scope [What should remain untouched or explicitly not be solved?]

[Type here]

2. Execution contract

Use this section to set autonomy, risk, quality, and communication expectations.

Success criteria [Observable checks that distinguish complete from merely attempted.]

[Type here]

Constraints and invariants [Must keep; must avoid; compatibility; style; performance; compliance; budget.]

[Type here]

Authority and permissions [Actions allowed without asking; actions requiring approval.]

[Type here]

GOOD DEFAULT Allow read-only inspection and reversible in-scope edits. Require confirmation for destructive actions, external messages, purchases, publication, credential use, or scope expansion.

Decision policy [When details are missing, should Codex infer, present options, or pause?]

[Type here]

Verification [Tests, renders, calculations, cross-checks, reviewers, or acceptance procedure.]

[Type here]

Communication [Update frequency, desired explanation depth, and when to escalate blockers.]

[Type here]

Final handoff [What the closing response must contain: links, summary, risks, commands, next steps.]

[Type here]

3. Optional task modules

Copy the relevant prompts into your brief. Skip modules that do not affect the result.

Use when	Add these details
Code / debugging	Repository and branch; runtime; target behavior; reproduction steps; logs; compatibility; files not to touch; tests and performance limits.
Research / analysis	Decision to support; date range; geography; acceptable sources; freshness; evidence standard; citation format; assumptions; comparison criteria.
Documents / slides	Audience; purpose; source material; length; brand or visual reference; structure; tone; editable output format; render and layout requirements.
Data / spreadsheets	Input schema; units; missing-value rules; transformations; formulas versus values; validation totals; charts; output schema; privacy constraints.
Images / design	Use context; dimensions; style references; composition; required and forbidden elements; text accuracy; brand colors; file format; variants.
Browser / UI work	Target URL or local app; account/session assumptions; exact user flow; browsers/viewports; permitted submissions; screenshot and evidence needs.
Automation / monitoring	Trigger; cadence; timezone; inputs; action; notification target; deduplication; failure handling; stop condition; archive policy.
External systems	Named service; account/workspace; records in scope; read versus write authority; recipients; draft versus send; audit trail; rollback plan.
High-risk domain	Relevant jurisdiction or policy; professional-review requirement; prohibited actions; uncertainty threshold; authoritative sources; explicit approval gates.

Useful preference switches

- Optimize for: [speed / correctness / maintainability / visual polish / cost / minimal change].
- Response style: [concise / explanatory / expert-level / tutorial].
- Tradeoffs: [choose the best default / show 2–3 options / preserve current approach].
- Progress: [work silently / send milestone updates / report each meaningful decision].
- Uncertainty: [state assumptions and continue / verify first / stop when confidence is below ____].

4. Paste-ready master prompt

Replace bracketed text and remove unused lines. This is the shortest complete version of the template.

TASK

[Name the task and describe the finished outcome.]

CONTEXT

[Explain why it matters, who it serves, the current state, and relevant history.]

INPUTS

[Attach or list files, links, examples, data, and sources. State source priority if they conflict.]

DELIVERABLES

[Specify artifacts or actions, formats, locations, and expected final handoff.]

SCOPE AND CONSTRAINTS

[State what is in scope, out of scope, must remain unchanged, and any deadline, compatibility, style, cost, privacy, or policy limits.]

AUTHORITY

[State what you may do without asking and what requires approval.]

WORKING POLICY

[State whether to infer reasonable details, offer options, or pause. Tell me how often to update you.]

QUALITY BAR AND VERIFICATION

[Define success criteria, required tests or checks, and what “done” means.]

OPTIONAL TASK-SPECIFIC DETAILS

[Add only the relevant module details from page 4.]

Please inspect the available context first, make reasonable in-scope assumptions explicit, complete and verify the work, and finish with a concise handoff covering the outcome, changed artifacts, verification performed, remaining risks, and the most useful next step.

Pre-send check

- The finished outcome is concrete and observable.
- All necessary inputs are attached or locatable.
- Scope, protected areas, and approval gates are explicit.
- The quality bar and verification method are stated.
- Optional detail is included only where it changes execution.